

MODULE 30 / 40

Northern Mockingbird

Mimus polyglottos

QUICK STATS

Length	8.3 – 10.2 in (21 – 26 cm)
Wingspan	12.2 – 13.8 in (31 – 35 cm)
Weight	1.4 – 2.0 oz (40 – 58 g)
Lifespan	Up to 14 years (avg. 8 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Northern Mockingbird is one of the most vocally gifted birds in the world — a medium-sized, gray-and-white songbird capable of learning and performing the songs of dozens of other species, sometimes singing continuously for hours without repeating itself. Its scientific name, *Mimus polyglottos*, means "many-tongued mimic," and it earns that title fully: a single male may have a repertoire of over 200 distinct song types. It is the state bird of five U.S. states — Arkansas, Florida, Mississippi, Tennessee, and Texas — and its bold, assertive personality makes it one of the most conspicuous birds in suburban and urban America.

HABITAT & RANGE

The Northern Mockingbird is a year-round resident across the southern half of the United States, from California to the Atlantic coast, and has expanded its range northward over recent decades, now regularly breeding in southern Canada. It thrives in open and semi-open habitats: suburban gardens, parks, hedgerows, roadsides, forest edges, and agricultural areas with scattered shrubs and trees. It shows a particular affinity for fruiting shrubs such as holly, pyracantha, and multiflora rose.

DIET & FEEDING

- Wild berries: holly, pyracantha, pokeweed, multiflora rose, elderberry
- Insects and earthworms — dominant in warm months
- Small fruits: crabapple, grape, hackberry
- Suet and mealworms occasionally at feeders
- Lizards and small frogs taken occasionally
- Flower nectar and fruit juice probed directly in summer

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Northern Mockingbirds are famously bold and aggressive, fearlessly attacking birds many times their size — hawks, crows, and even cats and dogs — that venture near their nesting or feeding territories. They maintain separate territories in summer (for breeding) and winter (for berry supplies), and defend both vigorously. Males are among the most persistent singers in North America, sometimes singing through the night during the full moon — a behavior that can test the patience of neighboring humans. Their wing-flashing display — spreading the wings suddenly to reveal white patches — may startle insects into movement, making them easier to catch.

NESTING & BREEDING

Northern Mockingbirds build bulky cup nests of twigs and plant material, lined with grasses and rootlets, typically in a dense shrub or small tree 3–10 feet above the ground. Both parents build the nest. Clutches of 3–5 pale blue-green eggs with brown spots are incubated primarily by the female for 12–13 days. Both parents feed the nestlings, which fledge at 11–13 days. Pairs raise 2–3 broods per season and are aggressively defensive near the nest.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

The Northern Mockingbird's song is a continuous, exuberant medley of imitated and original phrases, each repeated 3–5 times before switching to the next. A male may mimic cardinals, jays, hawks, frogs, car alarms, and squeaky gates — anything it hears repeatedly. Unmated males sing most persistently, sometimes all night. The call is a sharp "chuck" or harsh "chat." Song is heard year-round in warm climates.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Declining slightly
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The Northern Mockingbird population is estimated at 31 million individuals but has declined by roughly 21% since 1970. Loss of dense fruiting shrub habitat through suburban development and the removal of "weedy" hedgerows and thickets are the primary drivers. Planting native fruiting shrubs — especially holly and native roses — and maintaining dense hedges are the most effective ways to support this species.

FEEDER TIPS

- Plant native holly, pyracantha, and beautyberry — far more effective than feeders
- Mockingbirds rarely visit seed feeders; offer fruit pieces or mealworms on a platform
- They aggressively defend berry shrubs — plant enough for multiple birds
- A heated birdbath in winter is strongly attractive to them
- Expect them to chase other birds away from feeders — give them their own space

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Back & head	Medium gray
Wings	Dark gray with white wing patches
Tail	Long, dark; white outer feathers
Underparts	Pale gray-white
Eye	Pale yellow — striking
Bill	Long, slightly curved, dark

COLOR ME!

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